

**FITNESSWISE**

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The importance of Needs Analysis in sports science

By breaking down issues into specific components and working from a first-principles perspective, coaches and athletes have a **prospective shot** at success.

Imagine you're a Strength and Conditioning (S&C) professional who has been contacted by young athletes flourishing in their sport and ready to take their performance to the next level. To help them achieve that, they have reached out to you through a referral, say, a team that has been impressed with what you've demonstrated on social media regarding your competence in helping athletes achieve peak performance. However, the challenge you're now facing is, "How do I design a successful interpolation programme for this athlete?"

Needs Analysis is key to design

One effective way to address this challenge is by conducting a Needs Analysis to determine the starting point for the intervention.

What is a Needs Analysis? Essentially, it involves breaking down the first principles related to the individual, their sport, skills, environment, and other variables to understand where to start and what will be an effective programme to implement.

Let's go through some of these first principles and break them into simple sections, which are the most essential components for understanding the athlete and other variables in order to create a Needs Analysis.

WHO?

What are your athletes' backgrounds? Have they trained systematically before? What is their age? What is their history of injuries, if any? Do you know their preferred communication or training style? Will other coaches or support staff be involved?

WHAT?

What is the sport in question? Is there published research on training interventions for it? Is there specific

footage on platforms like *YouTube* or educational videos? Can you figure out the type of sport and the physiological systems it involves? What is the level at which the sport is being played? What other resources are available that can help you understand the sport and break it down into skill sets?

WHEN?

When will your athletes be training and competing in their sport? Is it in the morning, afternoon, evening, or night? When will they be able to complete the intervention around these schedules? What influence does the time of day have on your athletes' physiology and motivation? (Consider circadian rhythms, nutrition, recovery, and any personal schedule.)

WHERE?

Where will your athletes be completing this programme? At home or away ground? Abroad? Will you be monitoring them remotely, or coaching them in person, or will you need to appoint a coach for the location to monitor and collect necessary data?

WHY?

This is a big one. Why are your athletes engaging in this programme? What are their